

The Guest House

- Rumi

This being human is a guest house.
Every morning a new arrival.
A joy, a depression, a meanness,
some momentary awareness comes
as an unexpected visitor.

Welcome and entertain them all!
Even if they're a crowd of sorrows,
who violently sweep your house
empty of its furniture,

still, treat each guest honorably.
He may be clearing you out
for some new delight.

The dark thought, the shame, the malice,
meet them at the door laughing,
and invite them in.

Be grateful for whoever comes,
because each has been sent
as a guide from beyond.

Emotions and Religion

I remember the two families. A young man lay in our ICU. He'd been in an accident. At the moment he had tubes and wires all over his body. There were 8 monitors in his room. He was unresponsive. The situation was critical. It was touch and go. The doctors really couldn't tell the families if he would pull through or if they needed to prepare for his death.

Both families were strong Christians. Each family believed in Jesus, went to church, read their Bibles, and prayed. Yet, they had a very different faith. The young man's family held on to their belief that God would heal their son. God heard their prayers and the prayers of all the people on the prayer chain. God would answer those prayers. They were seldom tearful. They credited their ability to remain positive to their faith. They knew that God could do a miracle and restore their son to them. And they knew that expressing any doubt or negative emotion reflected on the depth and strength of their faith.

The other family were the parents of the young woman who had married the man lying unresponsive in our ICU. They were equally devout. They believed that God was with them during this horrible situation. They cried often. They were so sad, and scared, and frustrated. The roller coaster of watching their son-in-law improve and decline and improve and decline over and over was hard on them. They were not overly emotional. They did not believe that their experience of such powerful emotions reflected on the depth of their faith.

Both families spent days and then weeks together in our ICU waiting room. The patient's parents were worried that the negative emotions of his in-laws could affect the outcome of his health. They were uncomfortable with all the tears. In private conversations with the chaplains, an individual might wonder if they were cold hearted or in denial.

The in-laws were equally distressed. They worried that the young man's family did not fully appreciate the gravity of the situation. Would the family make poor choices because they were in denial? In private conversations with the chaplains, they thought perhaps, if they had more faith, they would not be so emotional. Their daughter was caught between the two families. Eventually the chaplains and hospital staff found that the best way to manage these differences was to keep the families apart.

The same situation. The same overall belief system. And opposite ends of the emotional spectrum.

Emotions are complex and nuanced. They're messy and they're tricky. Religion certainly is not cut and dried - it's complicated and multifaceted. The two of them are frequently linked, and when they are, it is anything but simple.

You've stopped listening to me now... you're probably wondering what happened with the young man, his wife, and their two families. It is a mixed ending. After a tortuous amount of time, it was clear that he would die and all

the experts in his healthcare team couldn't stop it. It was tremendously sad. It was also one of the most beautiful deaths I've seen. When the mechanical support was to be stopped, the young wife asked everyone to leave. She crawled into bed with her husband and held him. After he died, she invited both families into the room. In this holy moment, the families' differences dissolved. They all cried together, consoled each other, and joined together as the chaplain led them in prayer. The ICU staff was in tears. It was hard and it was holy at the same time.

OK, take a second. Notice what is happening in your body. Did your heart constrict, did your eyes become wet, did your body become heavy? What happened to your body at the end of the story?

Emotions are physical. They happen in our bodies. Frans De Waal offers a powerful study of human and animal emotions in his book 'Mama's Last Hug.'

"Emotions are observable and measurable, reflected in bodily changes and actions. Since human bodies are the same across the globe, emotions are by and large Universal, including what happens to us when we fall in love, have fun, or get mad. That is why we never feel emotionally disconnected even in a country where we don't speak the language. Feelings, on the other hand, are private experiences, varying from place to place and person to person. What one person experiences as pain, another may feel as pleasure. There is no simple one-to-one mapping between emotion and feelings." Emotions are physical.

Feelings are the interpretation we give to those physical responses. For example, if my heart is racing, my breathing is shallow, my chest is tight and my muscles are tense, I could be feeling fear, or excitement. Though the words emotions and feelings may be interchangeable in most circumstances, for today's sermon, emotions are biological, feelings are how we understand those physical responses.

Even as I say this, we know that everything is intertwined: Thoughts - Emotion - Behavior. Each impacts the other. Emotions do have a pattern. First there is stimuli, an event, a thought, an awareness. Then an emotion happens without conscious thought. And finally, every emotion carries an urge. For example, if we are out walking and come upon some nasty maggot filled roadkill, our immediate urge is to get away. The emotion of disgust propels us to get away from things and people that could harm us. Most emotions carry urges of moving toward or moving away from someone or something.

Emotions are universal. People all over the world make the same faces when they are happy, sad, angry, etc. Studies repeatedly confirm that if photographs of people in one part of the world are shown to people on the other side of the world, those viewing the pictures have no trouble correctly naming the emotions expressed. All these facial expressions and physical sensations are innate.

Children born deaf and blind still make the same faces when experiencing the same emotions. When deaf and blind athletes win an event, even if they

have never seen it, the athletes will puff out their chest, tilt back their heads, and raise their fists high over their head in a victory sign.

Scientists and researchers have some theories about this. The most predominant ones involve trust and communication. All animals, not just humans, have distinct signals for communicating. Combinations of movements and positions signal different things. A barking dog with a wagging tail has a whole different agenda than a barking dog with a ridged tail. Researchers have entire catalogs of these ethograms for hundreds of animals. There are also facial coding systems for humans with a special category for micro-expressions - those fraction of a second involuntary movements of the face that can't be hidden or faked. They show our true emotions. For a time there were several TV shows trying to use the study of micro-expressions as the secret weapon in crime solving dramas. It was too complicated for the viewer just wanting some entertainment.

Yet, micro-expressions are the way we detect the real meaning. Words don't matter if body language is saying something else. Just think of a smile. The corners of the mouth go up, but how far up do they go, what happens with the lips, what is going on with the skin around the eyes, where are the eyebrows, and what's the position of the head? We know, without putting it into words, the difference between a smile that is genuine, phony, mischievous, ironic, submissive or threatening. It is difficult to fully hide one's emotions; this promotes the trust and co-operation so necessary for our survival as a species.

Our ability to empathize is tied into all of this. We unconsciously mimic the facial movements of others we care about when we watch them. The way we move our face and body affects the way we think. It's an ingenious set up for "putting ourselves in someone else's shoes." Copying the face of another helps us have similar emotions. Not being able to mirror facial expressions hinders our ability to empathize. For this reason, people who have had botox and can't move facial muscles have been shown to be less empathetic. One can understand how face masks affected empathy and trust.

"Emotions are hard-wired into us. Yet they are not instinct. Emotions have the great advantage over instinct that they don't dictate specific behavior. Instincts are rigid and reflex like. Emotions focus the mind and prepare the body while leaving room for experience and judgment. They constitute a flexible response system far and away superior to instincts. Based on millions of years of evolution, the emotions "know" things about the environment that we as individuals don't always consciously know.... Emotion-based reactions are not automatic like instinct: they pass through a filter of experience and learning known as appraisal.... They still produce the desired behavioral change, but only after a careful evaluation of the situation." (Frans De Waal)

Emotions are not the opposite of cognition. Emotions are an integral part of it. Intelligence is not just in our heads. Our reasoning comes from our whole

body. It's interesting to note that we have brain cells not just in our head, but also in our heart and stomach. These brain cells are different from those in our head, but they are still responsible for reasoning. This is why statements like "I knew it in my heart" and "I had a gut feeling" are not just figures of speech. Artificial Intelligence scientists recognize that emotions are a flexible, vital part of thinking. Because of this, they are trying to find a way to give robots and A.I. computers emotions.

Emotions tell us about our world, yet they are not facts. Emotions tell us how we are perceiving and responding to what is going on. They give us information. Say we notice that we are angry at someone but have a clear reason. The anger informs us that our boundaries have been crossed, or that person is getting in the way of something we want. Emotions also reflect our thoughts. Most of us can think of an experience where we thought one thing, and had very strong emotions about it. But those emotions changed the instance we got different information. Since our emotions are influenced by our thoughts and impact our behavior, it's a good idea to ask ourselves if the emotion fits the facts. Do we have the right information?

We are also responsible for managing our emotions. Those who just let it all out wreak havoc. We change our emotions by changing our thoughts and posture. While there are many factors that influence our emotions: sounds, the weather, geography, illness, sleep, nutrition, and so on, we can best control what we do with our emotions and their urges by governing our thoughts and adjusting our postures. We can also regulate our feelings by acknowledging them and paying attention to them. This doesn't mean dwelling on them. It does mean attending to them. Maybe you've been told you need to "feel your feelings." So what does that mean? It is easy to start ruminating and analyzing our feelings and it's easy get stuck there. The most efficient way to "feel your feelings" is to become mindful of your emotions. If possible, be still for a short while, and notice what is happening in your body without judgement. When we focus on the physical sensations, they begin to change. We can then move on, rather than getting stuck in our feelings.

What about the two families I told you about at the beginning of the sermon? What role did religion play in their emotions?

What we believe drives much of what we feel. When I began research for this sermon, I expected to find that different religions had different stances about emotions. Certainly Buddhism has one attitude about emotions while Christians have another. Theology significantly impacts our thoughts, which impact our emotions.

Of course, anything having to do with religion is not that simple! Religion is tied to time and circumstance and culture. A Muslim man living in Persia during the middle ages has a very different religious relationship with emotions than a modern Muslim woman living in Des Moines, Iowa. Additionally there is such a

broad spectrum within one faith. A liberal Jew has more in common with a liberal Muslim than with an Orthodox Jew.

Yet, we can discern some common patterns when partnering religion and emotions. These patterns are not shaped by the particular faith tradition. They show up in all the major religions. There are nuances within each belief system, but the broad strokes are the same. Not surprisingly, religion is a double-edged sword. When religion has a negative view of emotions, it is often linked with an adverse view of the body. It fosters ideas of dualism. The mind is rational, superior; the body is full of uncontrollable urges and weakness. Just as the body must be controlled, emotions must be mastered and suppressed. It can work for the short term. Over time, this usually has unfortunate results. Buried emotions often come out sideways. People behave in ways that are abhorrent to the very faith they claim.

The suppression of emotions religiously works two ways if not addressed. Those who belong to unemotional religions tend to become more repressed. And people who are less emotional tend to gravitate toward these religious groups. When the intellect is admired and the body dismissed or despised, balance and full access to knowledge is lost. False equanimity by ignoring one's emotions is not enlightenment.

Now before my fellow cerebral Unitarian Universalists get defensive... First remember that UU'ism works to honor both the head and the heart. Our atheist UU's have chosen religious atheism / religious humanism. This is a balanced faith, not a zealous, angry denouncement of what seems to make no sense! A yearning for an intelligent faith does not necessitate stifled emotions!

It's also important to note that people experience emotions differently, because bodies have differences. Science has demonstrated that people who have high pain tolerance have less nerve endings than the individual with a low pain tolerance. Their emotions are distinct and moderate. A person with more nerve endings feels more pain. Their emotions are often complex and intense. Unfortunately, our society puts judgements around these different physical attributes. It does not serve anyone to idealize those who feel less pain as strong, stoic types of greater moral character and internal fortitude. Nor to relegate them as simpletons, feeling only glad, mad, and sad. Equally, it does no good to mock the sensitive soul as weak and dramatic or glamorize them as deep and profound. While experience and environment certainly influence us, the bottom line is that physical pain tolerance and emotional intensity are linked biologically. No one gets bragging rights.

There are eras when religions value emotions above reason. One particular instance began during the Renaissance. As science's reputation began to grow, it became harder to defend the Christian Bible. Protestant Christianity began to place greater importance on the role of feelings in faith. The veracity of the Bible was felt. It didn't have to be explained; one just knew it in their heart. From this thought process, it was an easy move to rely on emotions over teachings or tradition. All religious acts were subject to the emotional test: were believers

acting out of love instead of duty? It was not enough to do good. One had to be good for the right reasons. In the 1970-s through the mid-2000s, certain Protestant groups took this to the extreme. They used emotions to justify stupid actions. When a married church member ran off with another member's spouse, they would declare - "God's given us a peace about it." The rest of the church was left to pick up the pieces. When a religion distrusts emotions or over-values them, things get messy.

When religion is at its best, it brings a greater appreciation for the human body and the understanding that the body and mind are inseparable. Members of a faith are encouraged to acknowledge their emotions while managing them in healthy ways. Communities create bonding through shared emotions. A shared belief system cultivates similar emotions. Worship, study, charity and rituals all add to shared emotions. Rituals are designed to foster community connection. They also assist groups and individuals to cope with powerful events and emotions. Sacred texts express emotions, normalizing them and providing them legitimacy. Think of the Hebrew Bible's "Lamentations." Religious poetry is particularly expressive.

Religion inspires religious emotions. Emotions of awe, joy, peace, and oneness are often attached to religious experiences. People report that their lives are better for this and it has opened them up to broader and deeper encounters.

Religion helps its members regulate their emotions in a number of ways. Rather than denying it or suppressing it, religions give directions for exploring emotions safely, provide tools to soften distress, let go of attachments, connect to others, and use ritual to contain what sometimes seems uncontrollable. Religion is all about making meaning, which directly affects one's emotions. Finding a reason for life, its hardships and tragedies mitigates the chaos and fear that can be threatening if the universe is meaningless and everything is random.

Along with this, religion offers comfort and consolation. Some may argue that comfort can not be real if it is based on erroneous beliefs. *Stephen Asma address this in his book 'Why We Need Religion: An Agnostic Celebration of Spiritual Emotions'*

"...there is no such thing as false consolation. ... Some critics are making a category mistake, like saying: 'The colour green is sleepy.' Consolation or comfort is a feeling, and it can be weak or strong, but it can't be false or true. You can be false in your judgment of why you're feeling better, but feeling better is neither true nor false. True and false applies only if we're evaluating whether our propositions correspond with reality. And no doubt many factual claims of religion are false in that way – the world was not created in six days. Religion is real consolation in the same way that music is real consolation. No one thinks that the pleasure of Mozart's opera The Magic Flute is 'false pleasure' because singing flutes don't really exist. It doesn't need to correspond to reality."

And finally, emotion positive religion advances mindfulness. Buddhism is the master at this; other faiths encourage the same thing in a different way.

Buddhism does not teach that if one meditates enough, they can avoid emotions. Instead, it offers guidance about dealing with emotions when they arise.

Sylvia Boorstein explains this eloquently in her book 'It's Easier Than You Think.' *"Calmness and tranquility are lovely mind states, but they aren't the goal of practice, at least not for me. I want to be able to get excited. The more I realize that everything is empty and meaningless unless we imbue it with significance, the more I want to be able to imbue. Here I am in a life. I want to remember that it's only a movie, and I want to live it as if it's real."*

The bottom line is we are emotional beings. We are emotional with our whole being. And this is good. If we are mindful and manage our emotions, a world of knowledge, information, and emotional reasoning opens up to us. Religion can help us with emotions or it can hobble us. Most religions are open to the same emotional dangers and the same emotional gifts.

As you go about your days, as you notice how your body responds to people and events, as you determine the best course for your behavior - you may want to add it all into your experience of religious practice. Just as the body and intellect are woven together, so emotions and religion are intertwined. Can't you feel it?

Amen and Amen